

A brush with Death.

It's an absolutely beautiful day. There's a lazy heat that just wants me to enjoy the day and do whatever the hell I like; a vibe that is saying 'do nothing but enjoy this vibe.'

I'm with my mate, not a bestie, a guy with older brothers so he's a bit of an unknown quantity, and we're here at what they call the *Plunket* and have laid our towels down on a bit of flat rock, and we look just imposing enough to keep the other kids from coming over and crowding us out.

This *Plunket* is notorious and I have talked my mate into coming with me as I try it out. He reckons he and his brothers do it all the time. I'm a bit nervous. I've been around coastal rocks and the sea since I was able to walk but the waves and power of the ocean scare me. I need backup for this.

The swell surges up at me and just as quickly sucks away. The idea is to jump into that surge, the channel, as the wave comes up to meet me, be pulled down into the foaming crack in the rock, and then ride the next uplift back, to land, majestically on the flat rock platform where my beaming mate will be waiting.

I time it well; an explosion of bubbles, a shock of freezing foam, a clothes washing tumble of arms and legs, then a tiny hint of panic. I have absolutely no power. Its all with the *Plunket*. I'm a rag doll break dancing to its will. I'm fifteen, and I'm strong, lithe, skateboard nimble, I play basketball and squash for hours, I can walk for days up mountains in Katomba, I can hold my breath for minutes or more, I am invincible.

But the *Plunket* doesn't care. It has me in its grasp and will do what it wants. It holds me and spits its salty breath into me, down my nose, into my lungs. It twists and turns me, looking me over, seeing what I'm about. Do I count? No, it throws me over its shoulder.

Its not going at all how it should. I'm in deep trouble. I'm coughing on swallowed water. I can see my mate but I can't reach him. All majesty has been washed away and I'm flailing in the water grasping for a hand hold. I can't grip the rocks; the slimy scales of the *Plunket's* skin push me away. Its playing with me. An Orca throwing a seal about. There's blood in the water. Mine. The menace of un-recoverability, of death.

Did I mention I was fifteen. I've always recovered, I thought I always would. This is just part of the *Plunkett* experience, surely. Unless terrified, unless there's the thought of annihilation you haven't experienced the *Plunket* properly. You've come on a dud day. A pussy day. A girly day.

But things aren't as they should be. I'm in trouble. I catch my mate, in one of my snatched staccato glimpses above water, laughing and slapping his side at my antics.

But between gulps of air and the whipping of white choking water over my face I'm tiring. My panicked limbs are fading. It's an unknown feeling. I'm sinking in the terror of not surviving. I am literally dying and what's really strange, I can feel it happening.

I literally nearly die all the time. I throw myself about, skating in the nick-of-time between cars, climbing and scrambling the unclimbable, facing off against older boys with sneers and gestures. But I never really feel it.

But here, I'm dying right in front of me. My mate doesn't care. The *Plunkett* doesn't care. Even I have given up, my limbs are so exhausted, I've swallowed half the ocean, I can feel I'm slipping away. The surf's wash is just sweeping me back and forth in its indecision. With a calm that doesn't fit with the *Plunkett's* roaring rage, I absorb the elements into me. I'm am one with it now.

The *Plunkett* heaves one last time and I'm deposited back on a rock shelf spluttering like a landed fish and my mate is dancing around me whooping and hollering and slapping me on the back.

"That was fucking awesome!" he yells.